

Cabbage Seedling Grow Guide

For Caribbean Queen cabbage and general headed cabbage seedlings

Quick Rescue - Quick Numbers - Care - Harvest - Problems - Transplanting

Best For	Home gardens, kitchen gardens, raised beds, containers, and small farm rows
Main Goal	Grow a firm, clean cabbage head with steady moisture, enough spacing, and early pest control
Big Warning	Protect young cabbage early from caterpillars, aphids, rot, and heat stress

This guide is written for customers buying cabbage seedlings from ParaLife Trees. It covers both small farmer planting and home garden planting.

1. Quick Rescue: If You See This, Do This

Use this page first. Look at the plant, match the sign, and take the first action the same day.

What You See	Most Likely Cause	What To Do First
Small holes in leaves	Caterpillars, cabbage worms, loopers, diamondback moth larvae	Check leaf undersides. Remove worms and eggs. Use insect netting or safe caterpillar control. Repeat checks every 2-3 days.
Leaves full of tiny pale insects	Aphids or whiteflies	Spray undersides of leaves. Remove badly infested leaves. Repeat every 3-5 days. Control ants.
Seedling wilts after planting	Transplant shock, sun stress, dry roots	Water gently, shade for 2-3 days, avoid fertilizer for 5-7 days.
Yellow leaves and wet soil	Overwatering, poor drainage, root stress	Reduce watering, improve drainage, raise containers, avoid standing water.
Black V-shaped marks from leaf edges	Possible black rot	Remove infected leaves/plants. Do not splash water. Avoid touching healthy plants after sick ones.
Plant grows leaves but no firm head	Heat stress, crowding, low nutrition, irregular water	Give 6+ hours sun, steady water, correct spacing, and balanced feeding.
Head cracks open	Irregular watering after dry spell or late harvest	Harvest firm heads on time. Keep water steady. Mulch soil.
Roots swollen or distorted	Possible clubroot	Remove plant. Do not replant brassicas in that spot for 3-4 years. Improve drainage and pH.

2. Quick Numbers Page

Item	Specific Range / Target
Crop type	Headed cabbage / Brassica oleracea Capitata Group
Seed germination	5-10 days in warm, moist seed-starting conditions
Seedling transplant age	4-6 weeks after sowing
Best transplant size	4-6 true leaves; about 4-6 inches / 10-15 cm tall
Hardening-off period	5-7 days before planting in full outdoor conditions
Sunlight	At least 6 hours direct sun daily
Best growth temperature	15-21 C / 59-70 F; cabbage handles cooler weather better than hot weather
Heat stress risk	Above 27-30 C / 80-86 F, especially with dry soil or crowded plants
Soil pH target	6.0-7.0; avoid acidic, waterlogged soil
Water target	1-1.5 inches / 25-38 mm per week, more in hot or windy conditions
Spacing for small heads	12-15 inches apart
Spacing for larger heads	18-24 inches apart
Row spacing	24-36 inches between rows for hand work and airflow
Harvest after transplanting	60-100 days, depending on variety, weather, spacing, and nutrition
Harvest from seed	80-180 days depending on variety and season

For customer confidence: cabbage is not a quick leafy green like lettuce. It needs time, room, steady water, and pest protection before the head becomes firm.

3. Sunlight, Soil, and Water

Sunlight

- Give cabbage at least 6 hours of direct sun each day.
- In hot Jamaican conditions, morning sun plus good airflow is important.
- Avoid deep shade; shaded cabbage makes large loose leaves and poor heads.

Soil

Soil Need	Target
Texture	Loose, fertile, well-draining soil
Organic matter	Add compost or well-rotted manure before planting
Drainage	Water should soak in and drain; roots should not sit in mud
pH	6.0-7.0; closer to neutral helps reduce clubroot risk
Mulch	Use dry grass, straw, dry leaves, or compost mulch kept 1-2 inches away from the stem

Watering

Stage	Watering Direction
First 3 days after transplant	Check morning and evening. Keep root ball moist but not flooded.
First 14 days	Water consistently while roots settle. Do not let young plants wilt repeatedly.
Head formation stage	Keep soil evenly moist. Irregular water can lead to small heads or cracking.
Container growing	Check daily in hot weather. Containers dry faster than ground beds.

4. Feeding Guide

Cabbage is a heavy feeder compared with many herbs. It needs steady nutrition, especially nitrogen early, but overfeeding late can make soft growth and pest problems.

Stage	Timing	Feeding Direction
At planting	Day 0	Mix compost into the bed or pot. Use a balanced starter feed if available.
After settling	10-14 days after transplant	Feed lightly once plants show new growth.
Leaf-building stage	Every 2-3 weeks	Use compost, balanced fertilizer, or a nitrogen-support feed in moderate amounts.
Head formation	When center starts cupping/head starts forming	Keep nutrition steady. Avoid letting plants become pale.
Final 1-2 weeks before harvest	When head is near full size	Avoid heavy feeding. Focus on steady water and clean leaves.

Signs cabbage may need feeding

- Pale green leaves across the whole plant.
- Slow growth after the first 2 weeks.
- Small leaves and weak head formation.
- Older leaves yellowing too early while soil moisture is correct.

Avoid

- Fresh manure touching roots.
- Heavy fertilizer on newly transplanted stressed seedlings.
- Too much nitrogen late in the crop if heads are already soft and pests are present.

5. Harvesting Guide

Harvest Question	Answer
When to harvest	When the head feels firm and tight when pressed gently.
Time after transplant	Usually 60-100 days depending on variety and weather.
Best time of day	Early morning, before heat builds up.
How to cut	Use a clean sharp knife. Cut below the head, leaving a few outer wrapper leaves.
Do not wait too long	Overmature heads can split, crack, or become pest-damaged.
Storage after harvest	Keep heads shaded and cool. Do not leave harvested cabbage in sun.

Head Firmness Check

Press the head gently with your palm. A harvest-ready cabbage feels firm and filled out. A head that feels loose or leafy needs more time, unless pest or disease pressure means it should be harvested early.

Cracking Warning

Cabbage heads may crack if the plant dries out and then receives heavy water or rain, or if mature heads stay too long in the field. Mulch and regular watering reduce this risk.

6. Leaf Color and Problem Guide

Leaf / Plant Sign	Possible Cause	What To Do
Medium blue-green to green leaves	Normal for healthy cabbage	Continue steady care.
Pale green leaves	Low nitrogen, poor soil, low sunlight	Feed lightly, improve compost, increase sun.
Yellow lower leaves	Age, low nitrogen, overwatering	Check soil moisture first; feed if soil is not wet.
Purple tint	Cold stress, phosphorus stress, root stress	Improve root conditions, avoid waterlogging, feed balanced nutrients.
Brown leaf edges	Heat, drought, fertilizer burn	Water evenly, mulch, avoid strong fertilizer.
Small holes	Caterpillars/flea beetles	Inspect leaves every 2-3 days and protect early.
Black V-shaped lesions	Possible black rot	Remove infected leaves/plants and avoid water splash.
Wilting in wet soil	Root disease, poor drainage	Improve drainage; remove badly collapsed plants.

7. Head Formation Problems

Problem	Likely Cause	Action
Lots of leaves but no head	Plant too young, too hot, too shaded, too crowded, or weak nutrition	Give time, improve spacing, 6+ hours sun, steady feeding and water.
Small head	Crowding, low nutrients, dry periods, root restriction	Space 18-24 inches for larger heads; feed and water steadily.
Loose soft head	Heat stress, too much nitrogen, not enough sun	Improve airflow, avoid excess nitrogen, harvest when firm enough.
Head cracking	Irregular watering or late harvest	Keep water even and harvest firm heads on time.
Plant sends flower stalk	Heat, stress, old seedlings, wrong season	Harvest usable leaves/head quickly and replant in cooler timing.

Cabbage forms heads best when growth is steady. Repeated stress - drying out, flooding, crowding, severe pest damage, or heat - can interrupt head formation.

8. Small Farmer Notes

- Use clean seedlings and avoid planting cabbage after cabbage, broccoli, cauliflower, kale, or pak choy in the same bed too often.
- Use spacing of 18-24 inches between plants for larger heads; use 24-36 inches between rows for airflow and hand work.
- Install insect netting or row cover early where caterpillars are a regular problem.
- Walk the plot every 2-3 days during early growth to catch caterpillars, aphids, and disease signs early.
- Plant in batches every 2-3 weeks if you want a more regular harvest instead of one big harvest.
- Keep harvested heads shaded, clean, and off the ground.

Field Layout Example

Goal	Plant Spacing	Row Spacing
Small heads / tighter planting	12-15 inches	24 inches
Standard heads	18 inches	30 inches
Larger heads / easier airflow	24 inches	36 inches

9. Home Garden Notes

- For 2-6 plants, choose a sunny space with at least 6 hours of sun.
- Plant 18 inches apart if you want decent-sized heads.
- Use a container of at least 5 gallons per plant; 7-10 gallons is better for larger heads.
- Do not crowd cabbage in small pots; crowding gives smaller heads and more disease risk.
- Check under leaves every 2-3 days because caterpillars hide there.
- Mulch the pot or bed to keep soil moisture steady.

Container note: cabbage can grow in containers, but it needs more root room than herbs. A small 6-inch pot is not enough for a full cabbage head.

10. Clean Handling and Seedling Sanitation

Clean handling helps stop disease moving from plant to plant, especially when customers are buying seedlings in trays or groups.

- Wash hands before handling seedlings, especially after touching diseased plants, soil, or chemicals.
- Use clean scissors or knives for harvest.
- Do not move soil from sick plants to healthy plants.
- Do not splash muddy water onto leaves when watering.
- Remove diseased leaves from the growing area; do not leave them on the bed.
- Avoid working plants when leaves are wet if disease is present.
- Keep trays and pots off muddy ground where possible.

Brassica Rotation Warning

Cabbage is in the brassica family with pak choy, kale, broccoli, cauliflower, collard, and mustard. Do not plant these crops in the same soil again and again without rotation, because pests and diseases can build up.

11. Hardening Off Seedlings

This section is for customers planting seedlings from trays or small pots. Hardening off slowly prepares seedlings for direct sun, wind, and outdoor stress.

Day	Exposure
Day 1-2	Bright shade or gentle morning light for 2-3 hours.
Day 3-4	Morning sun for 3-4 hours; shade during hot afternoon.
Day 5-6	Longer outdoor exposure with protection from harsh midday sun.
Day 7	Ready to transplant, preferably late afternoon.

- Keep tray cells moist while hardening off.
- Do not let small root balls dry out.
- If seedlings wilt badly, move them back to shade and water gently.
- Do not fertilize hardening-off seedlings heavily while they are stressed.

12. Transplanting from Trays or Small Pots

Best Time to Transplant

- Early morning before 8:30 a.m. or late afternoon after 4:30 p.m.
- Avoid the hottest part of the day.
- Water seedlings 1-2 hours before planting.

Step-by-Step

- Prepare the bed or container before removing seedlings from the tray.
- Dig a hole slightly wider than the root ball.
- Gently remove seedling without breaking the root ball.
- Plant at the same depth as the tray soil level, or slightly deeper up to the first leaf base if stem is leggy.
- Press soil gently around roots; do not compact hard.
- Water immediately after planting.
- Shade for 1-3 days if sun is intense.
- Check daily for the first 7 days.

Spacing at transplant: 12-15 inches for small heads, 18-24 inches for larger heads, and 24-36 inches between rows.

13. Common Pests

Pest	Signs	First Action
Cabbage worms / loopers / diamondback moth larvae	Holes in leaves, green worms, black droppings, damaged center leaves	Inspect every 2-3 days. Handpick. Use insect netting. Treat early before head forms.
Aphids	Clusters of tiny insects, sticky leaves, curled leaves	Spray undersides. Remove heavily infested leaves. Repeat every 3-5 days.
Whiteflies	Tiny white insects fly up when touched; yellowing or sticky leaves	Spray leaf undersides and use yellow sticky traps.
Flea beetles	Tiny shot-holes in young leaves	Protect seedlings early; use fine netting; keep plants growing strongly.
Slugs and snails	Ragged holes, slime trails, damage worse after rain/night	Remove hiding spots; check early morning; raise containers; use safe barriers.
Cutworms	Seedlings cut near soil line	Check soil around base; use collars around young seedlings.

Cabbage pests often attack before the head forms. Early protection is easier than trying to clean worms out of a formed head.

14. Common Diseases

Disease / Disorder	Signs	What To Do
Black rot	Yellow V-shaped leaf edges, black veins, stunted plants	Remove infected plants/leaves. Use clean seedlings. Avoid splashing water. Rotate crops.
Clubroot	Swollen roots, wilting, poor growth, plant may collapse	Remove plant. Improve drainage and pH. Rotate away from brassicas for 3-4 years.
Downy mildew	Yellow patches on upper leaves; gray/purple growth underneath	Improve airflow. Water early. Avoid wet leaves at night. Remove affected leaves.
Alternaria leaf spot	Dark target-like spots on leaves	Remove affected leaves. Improve spacing. Avoid overhead watering.
Bacterial soft rot	Slimy, smelly rot in wet conditions or damaged heads	Remove affected tissue/plants. Avoid injury. Keep heads clean and dry.
Damping off	Young seedling collapses at soil line	Use clean seedling mix, avoid overwatering, improve airflow.

Disease Prevention Basics

- Buy clean seedlings.
- Rotate cabbage and other brassicas yearly where possible.
- Water at soil level and avoid leaf splash.
- Give enough spacing for airflow.
- Remove diseased plant material from the growing area.

15. ParaLife Trees Support

Need help with your cabbage seedlings?

- Send a clear photo of the full plant.
- Send a close photo of damaged leaves.
- Send a photo of the underside of the leaves.
- Send a photo of the soil, bed, pot, or tray.
- Send a photo of any insects, spots, or rotting areas you see.

WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415

Sources used for grow-guide ranges and pest/disease guidance

- University of Delaware Cooperative Extension: Cabbage fact sheet.
- Utah State University Extension: Cabbage in the Garden.
- UF/IFAS Gardening Solutions: Cabbage; buy clean plants to avoid black rot and irrigate early so leaves dry.
- Iowa State University Extension: Growing Cabbage in the Home Garden; 6+ hours sun and 60-100 days from transplants.
- Virginia Cooperative Extension: Cole crops; rotation and harvest when heads are firm.
- UC IPM: Cabbage pests and disorders, including clubroot, bacterial soft rot, and black blight/ringspot.
- NC State school garden crop guide: harvest ranges from sowing and transplanting.

ParaLife Trees - Planting a Life in Paradise